



GYAN



*who the model likes, where the upsets hide,
and one trophy in the middle of it all*

THE HEADLINE CALL



Spain to lift it

at 13.2%, the narrowest of front-runners over France and England

A four-expert ensemble forecast for the 48-team tournament. Educational and entertainment use only. Probabilities, not prophecies.

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A wide – open World Cup

GYAN is a forecasting model, not a fortune teller. It takes the new 48-team World Cup, runs it one hundred thousand times inside a computer, and reports how often each team walks away with the trophy. The answer this year is refreshingly uncommitted: five nations sit within roughly six percentage points of one another at the top, and the favorite is a favorite only by a whisker.

Spain lead the board at 13.2%, a step ahead of France at 11.2% and England at 9.2%, with reigning champions Argentina close behind at 8.7%. Portugal and Brazil round out a tight chasing pack. In plain terms: GYAN expects a European-flavoured top of the table, a familiar set of contenders, and a tournament where the difference between lifting the cup and flying home early is a couple of bounces of the ball.

What makes the model worth reading is not the order of the favorites, which you could guess from the betting market, but the way it gets there. GYAN blends four very different ways of judging a football team and lets the evidence decide how much each one is worth. The result is a board that mostly agrees with the market, occasionally argues with it, and is honest about which is which.

The pages that follow lay out the full picture: the champion board, a complete bracket with the trophy in the middle, every group with the model's projected order, a look at the Black Stars in Group L, and the one big disagreement between the model's footballing engine and the wisdom of the crowd.

HOW TO READ THIS

Percentages are chances, not promises. A 13% favorite is still far more likely to lose the tournament than to win it. That is the nature of a 48-team knockout.

The bracket is the single most likely path, not a guarantee. Think of it as the model's best guess if every tie went to the favorite, which of course they never do.

Gold means winner on every bracket line and group card. Green marks a side the model expects to advance.

When in doubt, trust the spread, not the decimal. The gap between second and sixth is small enough that any of them winning would barely raise an eyebrow.

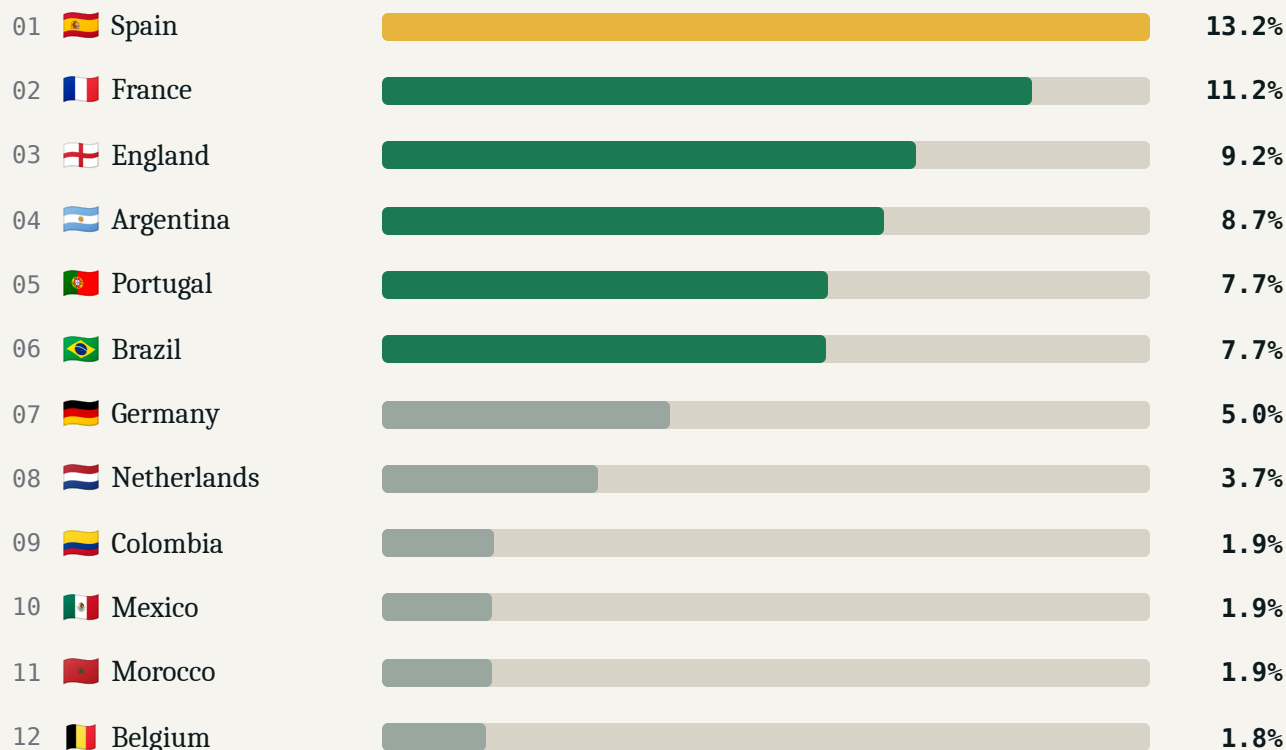
TOP OF THE BOARD

5

nations within ~6 points at the summit

The champion board

Model probability of lifting the 2026 World Cup. Top twelve of forty-eight.



Spain head the list, but the shape of the board matters more than the leader. The drop from first to sixth is gentle, which tells you the model sees no single dominant team, only a cluster of strong ones. Spain's edge comes from a kind draw, a deep squad, and a market that has quietly made them co-favorites through the spring.

Below the top six the air thins quickly. Germany and the Netherlands hover around the 4 to 5 percent mark, and beyond them sit the dark horses, Colombia, Mexico, Morocco and Belgium, each with a real but slim path. For context, Ghana, whose striker Asamoah Gyan gives this model its name, sits far down the list at 0.4%, roughly a one-in-250 shot. More on the Black Stars later.

TURN THE PAGE

The full bracket waits on the next spread, all the way from the Round of 32 to a single gold trophy in the center. Open it flat.

THE SIGNATURE SPREAD

The GYAN bracket

The most likely path through the knockouts, favorite by favorite. Real tournaments never run this cleanly, which is exactly the point.



GROUP BY GROUP

The groups, A to F

The model's projected order in each of the twelve groups. Top two advance automatically; the eight best third-placed teams join them in the Round of 32.

Group A

MODEL ORDER

1	 Mexico	WINS GROUP
2	 South Korea	ADVANCES
3	 Czech Republic	BEST THIRD
4	 South Africa	OUT

Group B

MODEL ORDER

1	 Switzerland	WINS GROUP
2	 Canada	ADVANCES
3	 Bosnia	BEST THIRD
4	 Qatar	OUT

Group C

MODEL ORDER

1	 Brazil	WINS GROUP
2	 Morocco	ADVANCES
3	 Scotland	OUT
4	 Haiti	OUT

Group D

MODEL ORDER

1	 United States	WINS GROUP
2	 Turkey	ADVANCES
3	 Paraguay	BEST THIRD
4	 Australia	OUT

Group E

MODEL ORDER

1	 Germany	WINS GROUP
2	 Ecuador	ADVANCES
3	 Ivory Coast	BEST THIRD
4	 Curacao	OUT

Group F

MODEL ORDER

1	 Netherlands	WINS GROUP
2	 Japan	ADVANCES
3	 Sweden	OUT
4	 Tunisia	OUT

The groups, G to L

Group G

MODEL ORDER

1	 Belgium	WINS GROUP
2	 Iran	ADVANCES
3	 Egypt	BEST THIRD
4	 New Zealand	OUT

Group H

MODEL ORDER

1	 Spain	WINS GROUP
2	 Uruguay	ADVANCES
3	 Cape Verde	OUT
4	 Saudi Arabia	OUT

Group I

MODEL ORDER

1	 France	WINS GROUP
2	 Norway	ADVANCES
3	 Senegal	BEST THIRD
4	 Iraq	OUT

Group J

MODEL ORDER

1	 Argentina	WINS GROUP
2	 Austria	ADVANCES
3	 Algeria	BEST THIRD
4	 Jordan	OUT

Group K

MODEL ORDER

1	 Portugal	WINS GROUP
2	 Colombia	ADVANCES
3	 DR Congo	BEST THIRD
4	 Uzbekistan	OUT

Group L

MODEL ORDER

1	 England	WINS GROUP
2	 Croatia	ADVANCES
3	 Panama	OUT
4	 Ghana	OUT

The Black Stars in the long grass

There would be no GYAN without Asamoah Gyan. The model is named for the Black Stars striker, Ghana's talisman of 2010, so it is only fair to say plainly where it thinks his country now stands. The honest answer: this is a hard draw.

Ghana land in Group L alongside England, Croatia and Panama, and on the model's reading they are the outsiders of the four. By world ranking they sit lowest in the group, behind a deep England side, a seasoned Croatia, and a Panama team the model rates as live. GYAN projects Ghana to finish fourth in the group in its single most likely bracket, with England winning the group and Croatia second in a rematch of their 2018 semi-final.

That is the cold version. The warmer version is that the group stage is not a coin landing once; it is three matches, and Ghana have a real pulse. Across the full simulation the Black Stars reach the knockout rounds far more often than their 0.4% title price suggests, because the new Round of 32 is forgiving to third-placed sides, and tournament football has a long history of ignoring rankings once the whistle blows. Ghana have been the team that makes the continent hold its breath before, most famously in 2010. Group L is tough, not closed.

Ghana arrive under a new hand. Carlos Queiroz, the vastly experienced Portuguese coach, took charge only in April after Otto Addo's exit, and will look to Antoine Semenyo and captain Jordan Ayew to carry the threat. The fixtures are kind in sequence if not in difficulty: Panama first, then the heavyweight against England, then Croatia to close. Win the opener and the whole group reshapes.

GHANA AT A GLANCE

Group	L
Model finish	4th
Title chance	0.4%
FIFA rank	74
WC appearance	5th
Best result	QF, 2010
Coach	C. Queiroz

THE FIXTURES

-  v  Panama · Jun 17, Toronto
-  v  England · Jun 23, Boston
-  v  Croatia · Jun 27, Philadelphia

A note on that knockout figure: it reflects how often a Pot-4 side of Ghana's shape escapes the group across many simulated draws, not a precise standalone promise. Read it as encouragement, not a ticket.

Four left standing

SEMI-FINAL ONE

 Spain v  France

The model's pick for the heavyweight semi, and on its numbers the tighter of the two. Spain edge it on the strength of a smoother projected route and a marginally higher title price. France, the model's second favorite overall, are the side most likely to make GYAN look foolish here.

SEMI-FINAL TWO

 England v  Argentina

England against the reigning champions. The model gives England the edge in its single most likely bracket, but this is the tie where the model and its own footballing engine disagree most, as the next page explains. Argentina are far stronger here than the headline board lets on.

THE FINAL

 Spain

v

 England



SPAIN, CHAMPIONS

THIRD PLACE • A REMATCH WITH HISTORY

 France v  Argentina

Of all the ties the bracket throws up, this is the one to circle. The model sends the two beaten semi-finalists into a third-place match that happens to restage the 2022 final, the night Argentina beat France on penalties in one of the great World Cup deciders. Here the roles soften and the stakes shrink, but the names do not. GYAN narrowly favors France this time, on the strength of a higher title price, a quiet inversion of that famous evening in Qatar.

A third-place playoff rarely sets pulses racing. This one, between two of the planet's best teams and freighted with a four-year-old grudge, might be the exception.

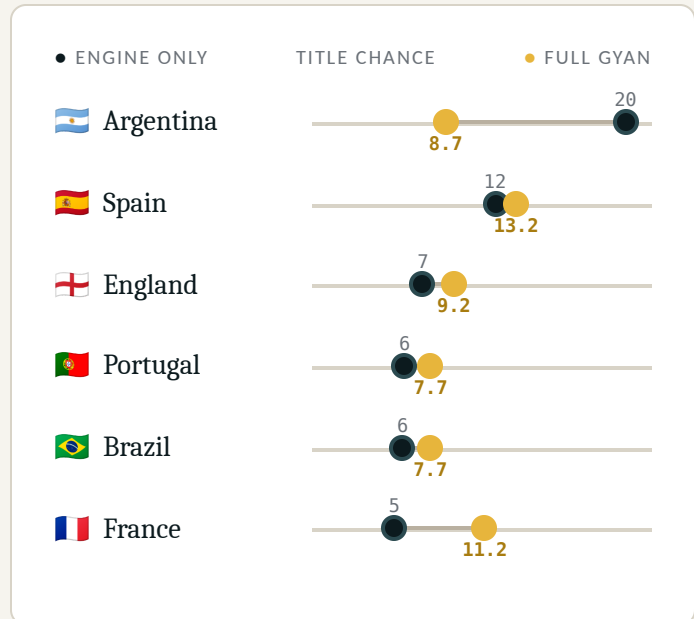
The model versus the crowd

Where GYAN's footballing engine and the betting market pull in different directions.

Strip GYAN back to its pure footballing engine, the part built on team ratings and goals alone, and a very different favorite appears. On strength and recent form, the engine adores **Argentina** and makes them a runaway leader at 20.3%, comfortably clear of the field. They are, after all, the reigning world champions with an elite rating.

The full model does not see it that way. Once the wisdom of the betting market is folded in, and the market carries roughly two thirds of the model's weight, Argentina slide all the way to fourth at 8.7%. Spain climb to the top and France leap from sixth to second. The crowd, in short, is more worried about Argentina's group and route, and more taken with Spain and France, than a strength-only view would be.

Which is right? Nobody knows yet; that is what the tournament is for. But the gap is the single most interesting number in the whole model, and worth keeping in mind every time Argentina take the field.



Each line runs from the engine's view (dark) to the final blended view (gold). Argentina's is the long one.

The fine print

A word before you frame the bracket. If you read what follows as prophecy, you are setting yourself up to be the friend at the party explaining, very loudly and very late, why a 13 percent favorite was a stone-cold lock all along.

GYAN does not know who wins the 2026 World Cup. Nobody does, and anyone who tells you otherwise is selling something, probably a tipster newsletter. What GYAN offers is a tidy, honest accounting of how the probabilities lean today, given imperfect data and a model candid about its own blind spots. Treat the whole thing as a well-read friend's opinion over a pint, not a message from the football gods.

In that spirit of honesty, here is a confession in advance. There is a well-worn catalog of excuses that forecasters reach for when reality declines to cooperate, cataloged by the psychologist Philip Tetlock and sharpened by the investor James Montier. They are funny precisely because they are so familiar. GYAN hereby swears off all five.

1 • THE "IF ONLY" DEFENSE

"Spain would have won, if only the manager had picked the obvious XI." This is the forecaster quietly rewriting the tournament until it matches the prediction. **The GYAN pledge:** the bracket you see is the bracket we are judged on, starting eleven and all.

2 • THE "ALL ELSE EQUAL" DEFENSE

"Holding everything else constant, we nailed it. Shame about the red card, the rain delay and the freak own goal." All else is never equal; that is rather the point of playing the games. **The GYAN pledge:** upsets, extra time and shootouts are already baked into all hundred thousand simulations. "Something unexpected happened" is not our excuse, it is our input.

3 • THE "ALMOST RIGHT" DEFENSE

"We said semi-final, they went out in the quarters. Practically the same thing." In knockout football, almost right is a flight home. **The GYAN pledge:** we publish probabilities, not vibes, and a near miss is scored as a miss, to two decimal places, without mercy.

4 • THE "HASN'T HAPPENED YET" DEFENSE

"Our dark horse will come good. Possibly by 2030." A forecast for this World Cup that only pays off at the next one is not a forecast, it is a horoscope with a longer expiry date. **The GYAN pledge:** every claim on these pages expires on 19 July 2026, along with the tournament.

5 • THE "ONE TOURNAMENT PROVES NOTHING" DEFENSE

"A single World Cup is a tiny sample. Grade me after a few more." True, and wonderfully convenient. **The GYAN pledge:** we volunteer our grades up front. This method has already been scored across 2014, 2018 and 2022; the numbers live in the technical paper, and you are invited to hold this board to exactly the same standard.

THE SHORT VERSION

Enjoy the bracket. Argue with it. Screenshot it so you can be smug in July. Just do not mistake a careful set of probabilities for a promise, and do not put money on it. That is not what it is for.

How GYAN actually works

In one sentence: GYAN runs four independent "experts" over every team, blends their opinions in proportions tuned on past World Cups, and then plays the tournament out a hundred thousand times. The four experts each answer a different question.

THE GOAL EXPERT

Judges teams on ratings and goals, using a classic football scoring model anchored to Elo strength. This is the part that loves Argentina.

THE YIELD EXPERT

Reads the named 26-man squads, values every player, leans younger, and docks points for injuries. Talent on the teamsheet, priced.

THE SOCIOECONOMIC EXPERT

A nod to the old idea that football strength has economic and demographic roots, blended with current world-ranking points.

THE MARKET EXPERT

Listens to the betting and prediction markets, stripped of their built-in margin. It carries about two thirds of the final say.

The blend is not guesswork. The weights are chosen to score as well as possible on the 2014, 2018 and 2022 tournaments, then sense-checked by holding out one tournament at a time. The market's heavy share is earned, not assumed, which also means GYAN agreeing with the market is more a sign of alignment than of independent genius. The full mathematics lives in the companion technical paper.

IMPORTANT • PLEASE READ

This forecast is provided for educational and entertainment purposes only. It is not betting advice, financial advice, or a guarantee of future results. Model outputs are probabilistic estimates based on imperfect data and assumptions, and they should not be used for wagering, investment decisions, or other high-stakes decisions.

SOURCES AND INFLUENCES

Dixon & Coles (1997), goal model. Hoffmann, Ging & Ramasamy (2002), socioeconomic determinants. Tetlock (2005) and Montier (2010), the five forecasting excuses. Groll et al. (2019). Murphy (1970), the scoring rule. World Football Elo (eloratings.net); Transfermarkt; FIFA ranking; Polymarket, Kalshi and bookmaker outrights. Benchmarks: Nate Silver's PELE, Goldman Sachs, and Joachim Klement's Panmure Liberum notes.

COLOPHON

GYAN: Goal-model, Yield-weighted Aggregation, simulation. Named after Asamoah Gyan, the Ghana Black Stars striker. Built in Python. Run tag 20260610:223240, seed 20260611, market snapshot 10 June 2026. One hundred thousand simulated tournaments. Set in GFS Baskerville, Caladea and DejaVu Mono.



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